Is Ballon d'OR the right award?

"A closer look at the Ballon d'Or: Does it accurately represent the best player?"

Ballon d’Or is a football award given to the best player of the season by the FFF, it is the most prestigious award in football and only the best players can get their hands on it, the criteria to win this takes Individual and collective performance from the previous season, a player's class and their career. This is done by voting from the "diverse international jury" of voters made up of national team coaches and captains from a selection of FIFA's 209 national associations, in addition to "specialist journalists. Only one journalist per country may vote. They are allowed to select players who play in or are affiliated with their own country. National team captains cannot vote for themselves but can vote for national or club colleagues. Last year, the panel consisted of 509 voters, which was made up of 170 national team captains, 170 national team coaches, and 169 journalists. Ballon D’or consists of many awards like the Kopa Trophy given to the best U-21 player in the world. Yashin Trophy named after the great Lev Yashin given to the best Goalkeeper of the season. The Gerd Muller Trophy is given to the best Striker of the year. Club of the Year is given to the best Club of the season. Socrates’ award is given for humanitarian efforts made by a player. In 2018, France Football introduced the Women's Ballon d'Or, recognising the best female footballer in the world. The criteria and voting process for the women's award are similar to the men’s.

The Ballon d'Or was created to honor the best European footballer of the year. The inaugural award was won by Stanley Matthews, an English footballer playing for Blackpool. Until 1994, only European players were eligible for the award. The opportunity to vote was extended to national team captains and coaches in 2007. In 2007, the medal was elevated to a global honor, making any professional football player worldwide eligible. France Football changed the Ballon

d'Or regulations in 2022. They adjusted the scheduling such that honors were awarded for a football season rather than for accomplishments over the course of a calendar year. It was also determined that only the top 100 FIFA World Ranking nations would be permitted to cast ballots.

Cristiano Ronaldo and Lionel Messi have combined to win the Ballon d’OR 12 times in the past 15 years. They had the Ballon D'or for 10 years straight from 2008-2018. Messi has won the award 7 times in his career and is looking to add one more this year and Ronaldo has won this award 5 times in his career. In clubs, the two powerhouses have won it the most times Real Madrid and Barcelona with 12 times their players have won the Ballon d'Or.

Is Ballon d’OR still the same?

Singling out one player as the best, regardless of where they play, is fundamentally unfair in a sport like football where various positions have radically different functions. The focus on attacking strikers and midfielders in the award's history is another factor that has been criticised. Outfield players have traditionally been given more recognition, while goalkeepers and defenders have had fewer opportunities to win the award However, France Football, which just recently created a distinct trophy known as the Yashin Trophy for the greatest goalkeeper, takes special joy in grouping all outfield players and formerly goalkeepers, too in the competition for the best. As a result, attacking strikers and midfielders almost always prevail. Only one custodian, the legendary Soviet Union's Lev Yashin in 1963, has won the Ballon d'Or in its whole history, as well as only one defender, Italy's 2006 World Cup-winning captain Fabio Cannavaro has won it in this century. This prejudice damages the award's overall credibility by ignoring the accomplishments of players who play roles that are just as crucial to a team's success.

At the Ballon d'Or presentation in 2019, Dutch defender Virgil van Dijk came second to Messi despite faring far better than the Argentine in the most crucial continental competitions. In 2014, goalkeeper Manuel Neuer saw his chances snuffed out in a face-off against goal-scoring machine Ronaldo despite being between the sticks during Germany's World Cup glory in Brazil. A year before that, Ronaldo had seen off Neuer's then-club teammate, Frenchman Franck Ribéry who had called it an "injustice", even though it was Ribéry who had stood out in the biggest games. The putative explanation among Ronaldo acolytes was that the Portuguese had amassed more goals and assists that year, something which could only guarantee a fifth place for Messi when Croatia's Luka Modrić attained pole position in 2018.

The domination of Lionel Messi and Cristiano Ronaldo in the award over the previous years is one contributing reason. Some people feel that the Ballon d'Or award has lost its thrill and has become predictable because these two players have won it in 12 out of the last 15 years. The question of whether the award represents the greatest player of the season or if it has turned into more of a popularity contest has also arisen as a result of this domination.

The Ballon d'Or is awarded based on a number of factors, including player class, career, and individual and team achievement. Some, however, contend that rather than concentrating only on the season's finest player, the award has changed into more of a popularity contest, with marketing and reputation influencing the results.

In conclusion, the Ballon d'Or, which recognises the top player of the season, has long been recognised as the highest honour given to an individual in football. However, it has come under fire and had its integrity and fairness called into doubt. Key grounds of criticism have been the domination of Lionel Messi and Cristiano Ronaldo, the preference for offensive players, and the lack of respect for goalkeepers and defenders. Debates regarding whether the award accurately represents the greatest player of the season have also been sparked by the voting procedure for the award and the possible effect of popularity and notoriety.